

► Magic bronze mirror, Tang Dynasty

The front of this mirror has a shiny, reflective surface but the back, shown here, has a design cast on it. When the sun or a light shines on the front surface, the mirror becomes transparent and, as if by magic, the pattern on the back can be projected onto a wall behind it.



Writhing dragon, a magical symbol of power, on the back of the mirror

Corroded bronze surface

inscriptions in the Shang Dynasty. By the time of the Han Dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE) *ku* was so widespread that it became punishable by death. *Ku* practitioners were believed to be able to pass disease into a victim's body (*ku* can be translated as "worms in the belly") or to poison people outright. The most effective venom was said to be obtained by sealing several toxic creatures, such as scorpions, centipedes, and snakes, in a jar and extracting the poison from the one that survived. *Ku* sorcerers were also said to sometimes turn their targets into slaves utterly obedient to their will. They were able to inflict even wider damage by unleashing the *wug*, a magical pest that could destroy whole harvests of grain.

"Those who dare to poison people with *ku* ... will be publicly executed."

ZHOULI ("RITES OF ZHOU"), c.300 BCE



Demons out and about

In this painted scroll, several grotesque demons parade through the countryside. They are the retinue of Zhong Kui, a legendary magician known as the Demon Queller, who was said to have cured Emperor Xuanzong in the 8th century CE of a fever by slaying a demon inside the ruler's dream.